Ester Borges Frickes Ricardo

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Education

Northwestern University — Evanston, IL

B.A. in Computer Science & Learning Sciences | GPA: 3.5/4.0 — *Sep. 2025 – Jun. 2029*

- **Coursework:** Data Structures & Algorithms (in progress), Data Structures, Discrete Mathematics, Linear Algebra, Design of Technological Tools for Thinking and Learning.
- **Fellowships:** Undergraduate Research Assistant Program (URAP) Fellow; Buffett Institute Atlas Fellow.

Experience

CGI — Remote

Product Intern, Enterprise AI Adoption — *Jun. 2026 – Sep. 2026*

- Led mixed-methods discovery on enterprise AI adoption, joining a 293-response employee survey with 30-day behavioral logs from 3,400+ LLM seats to quantify the gap between reported and actual usage.
- Surfaced the core insight that 86% of employees said AI improved their understanding while only 49% could solve an equivalent problem unaided, reframing the roadmap around cognitive overreliance rather than adoption volume.
- Segmented stakeholders across generational and functional lines (technical vs. creative roles) to specify differentiated guidance requirements per user group.
- Scoped and built FORGE, a React prototype on the Claude API, translating those findings into two testable interaction patterns: users state an approach before generating, and the assistant surfaces trade-offs requiring an explicit decision.

Access+ (nonprofit; WorldSkills, HP Foundation & UNESCO-UNEVOC supported) — Remote

Co-founder & Chief Operations Officer — *Jan. 2024 – Present*

- Grew a free academic-opportunity platform to 5,000 registered users and 100,000+ site visits across 13 Brazilian states and 8 countries, with 290+ curated opportunities and 10+ institutional partnerships.
- Ran primary research with students aged 13–24 across 13 states to size the problem: 93% wanted a single platform to find opportunities and 90% reported difficulty accessing extracurricular activities.
- Designed a tiered access model keeping the database free for all students and subsidizing AI matching for public-school and low-income users, funded by paying private schools and sponsored listings.

Northwestern University, Feinberg School of Medicine — Chicago, IL

Research Assistant — *Jan. 2026 – Jun. 2026*

- Researched LLM-based conversational rehearsal tools for difficult communication scenarios; thematically coded 300+ pages of user interview transcripts and co-developed the team codebook. Analyzed users' perceptions of AI anthropomorphism across the interviews, the literature review, and the interview features built for the project.

Projects

Seensory | *Participatory design, accessibility research, ACM-format paper* — 2026

- Designed a browser extension concept making fanfiction platforms usable for blind and low-vision readers, running participatory design sessions with three reader communities to ground requirements in how they actually read rather than in compliance checklists.
- Documented the problem framing, design rationale and open questions in an ACM-format paper and a recorded talk.

AccessIA | *Product definition, LLM-assisted matching, Supabase/PostgreSQL* — 2026

- Owned Access+'s AI assistant from problem definition to launch: scoped a 5-step intake around the signals that actually change a match, and specified eligibility filtering across 290+ opportunities with weighted ranking.
- Added an LLM review layer over the top-ranked candidates to read the free-text responses and unstructured eligibility text that filters alone could not, then shipped it as the platform's primary discovery path.

Leadership

Women in Computing, Northwestern University — Evanston, IL

Internal Outreach Chair — *2026 – Present*

- Created and led the chapter's flagship annual event, recruiting the Dean of Engineering and the University Dean as speakers and owning the $2,000 budget across venue, catering and marketing.
- Increased member engagement 84% by launching a members' group chat and organizing the chapter's Spring Banquet (70+ attendees).

BRASA Northwestern — Evanston, IL

Recruiting Chair — *2026 – Present*

- Lead the onboarding process for 13 incoming Brazilian freshmen at Northwestern's Brazilian student association, running outreach and the member selection process.

Skills

Product: problem framing, requirements definition, roadmapping, prioritization, success metrics, MVP scoping, prototyping, business modeling

Technical: Python, JavaScript, SQL, React, Supabase/PostgreSQL, Figma, Claude API, NetLogo

Spoken: Portuguese (native), English (advanced), French (intermediate), Spanish (beginner)

Honors & Awards

Top 15 of 800, BeChangemaker 2024 – only Brazilian team ever to rank Top 15.

Business Case Winner, International Economics Olympiad Winter Challenge – 3rd of 150 teams from 68 countries.

Silver Medal, Mathematiques Sans Frontieres International Mathematical Olympiad; Bronze Medalist (top 0.06% of 17M students) and 2x Honorable Mention, OBMEP.